them may require more than one sensor reading. Sleeping position, the frequency of oxygen drops and patterns across multiple nights can all provide useful context.

Oura's proposed patch seems to be a different approach- combining these signals rather than relying on a single metric. The patent also suggests that the device can be placed at different locations on the body, possible positions around the forehead, neck, chest and behind the ear.

That flexibility can matter if the company eventually decides to develop specialised wearables for specific monitoring needs. Instead of asking one device to track everything, manufacturers can make smaller products around particular signals or use cases.

For now, that remains a possibility rather than a confirmed product strategy. Still, the patent raises an interesting question about whether the next phase of wearable technology will be defined by more capable smartwatches and rings, or by devices designed to monitor health in more targeted ways.

Oura's patent focuses on identifying different types of sleep apnoea

The new patent is said to refine the concept by placing emphasis on differentiating the obstructive and central sleep apnoea. For the unversed, the OSA occurs when the upper airway becomes blocked or narrowed during sleep, interrupting normal breathing. For some people, these episodes become more frequent when sleeping on their backs. CSA is different. It occurs when the brain temporarily fails to send the signals required to control breathing, and its relationship with sleep position can differ from that of OSA, as per reports.

According to the patent, the proposed system can use a person's sleeping position alongside the amount and frequency of blood oxygen desaturation to estimate which type of apnoea may be involved.



In practice, this can mean identifying whether breathing disturbances and oxygen drops tend to coincide with a particular sleeping position, rather than simply flagging that something unusual happened during the night when you were asleep.

The system is also described as collecting information over several nights. This can help it establish a baseline for an individual's typical oxygen levels and sleeping positions before identifying patterns that may warrant further investigation.

The patent additionally discusses monitoring changes during positive airway pressure (PAP) therapy, which is commonly used to treat obstructive sleep apnoea. Comparing oxygen levels and breathing-related events over time may potentially help assess whether these indicators change during treatment.

Ofcourse, these capabilities can make the proposed patch more specialised than a general wellness tracker. However, the patent alone does not establish how accurate the system will be or even if it can distinguish the two conditions reliably or whether it would receive regulatory clearance for medical use.

Can specialised wearables be the next step after rings?

The broader wearable market already shows that consumers are willing to look beyond the traditional smartwatch. Smart rings have gained attention by offering sleep and recovery tracking in a smaller form factor, while screenless bands have explored a different balance between comfort, battery life and health insights.

I think the patent hints that the wearable industry will definitely move further. Rather than being designed primarily for everyday interaction or broad fitness tracking, it can be built around a particular monitoring requirement. That opens up the possibility of wearables for sleep, stress or other physiological measurements that benefit from a different placement on the body.

However, the success will depend on whether such devices offer useful information without introducing too much friction. Another challenge can be the relevant data. More data does not necessarily mean better health insights. The value of a specialised wearable would depend on the reliability of its measurements, how clearly it explains its findings and whether those findings help users make informed decisions.